For three weeks, the protesters at Jantar Mantar in Delhi could be ignored, mocked or dismissed as another social media spectacle. That ended on July 20, when tens of thousands answered the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) call to march on Parliament on the opening day of the monsoon session. Barricades fell, tear gas spread through central Delhi, and a movement with an improbable name forced itself into the centre of national politics. The immediate trigger was the leak of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test for Undergraduate, or NEET-UG 2026, question paper. The protesters demanded accountability for the lapse, the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan and justice for students betrayed by the system meant to serve them. But soon NEET became only the most visible sign of a deeper breakdown: leaked examinations, cancelled recruitment tests, unfilled vacancies and years of preparation wiped out by fraud, delay or administrative failure.

The protesters were overwhelmingly Gen Z, or those born between 1997 and 2012, and largely peaceful. Their weapons were placards, memes and slogans. Asked why they had come, only a few said it was because of the NEET paper leak. "Nothing works," said Samreen, 26. "The air you breathe is poison. Exams don't happen. When they do, results take years. There are no jobs. No one listens. And when you speak, they unleash the police. Are we criminals?" Stay longer, and the anger began revealing multiple strands of grievances: that there are no fair chances, that a degree no longer guarantees a job, that institutions are slow to explain, slower to correct mistakes and slowest to punish those responsible.

WHY THE RAGE

The anger at Jantar Mantar was sparked by an examination system that tests the patience of millions. NEET-UG is the sole gateway to undergraduate medical education in India. On May 3, over 2.21 million candidates sat the exam for roughly 137,000 MBBS seats. A "guess paper" had already circulated on Telegram and WhatsApp in coaching hubs, including Sikar in Rajasthan and Latur in Maharashtra. Some 120

2.21
MILLION
Candidates who appeared for NEET in May 2026

11-21
NEET ASPIRANTS
reported to have died by suicide between the paper cancellation and re-test on June 21

25.6
MILLION
Followers of the Cockroach Janta Party's official Instagram account

60
PROTESTERS
injured at Jantar Mantar on Jul. 20, as per police; CJP claims 150+

70
PROTESTERS
detained; 15-20 govt vehicles vandalised

Tens of thousands answered the Cockroach Janta Party's call to march on Parliament on the opening day of the monsoon session

VOX POP

"PAPER LEAKS STEAL FUTURES"

SEEMA BHIL | 23
Nurse and competitive exam aspirant, Mewar, Rajasthan



When governments repeatedly fail to solve fundamental problems, people are left with no option but to take to the streets. I came to Delhi without telling my parents. I only told my brother, who is preparing for UPSC exams. I'm standing here today for his future too. If an exam like the UPSC is hit by paper leaks tomorrow, years of my family's hard work will be wasted.